When the Towers Fell

By Galway Kinnell

From our high window we saw the towers
with their bands and blocks of light
brighten against a fading sunset,
saw them at any hour glitter and live
as if the spirits inside them sat up all night
calculating profit and loss, saw them reach up
to steep their tops in the until then invisible
yellow of sunrise, grew so used to them
often we didn't see them, and now,
not seeing them, we see them.

INTRODUCTION

September 11, 2001. On that morning, Nineteen Islamist terrorists affiliated with al-Qaeda hijacked four commercial passenger jet airliners. The hijackers intentionally crashed two of the airliners into the Twin Towers of the World Trade Center in New York City, killing everyone on board and many others working in the building. Both buildings collapsed within two hours, destroying at least two nearby buildings and damaging others. The hijackers crashed a third airliner into the Pentagon. The fourth plane crashed

4NG Fanatics

into a field near Shanksville in rural Somerset County, Pennsylvania, after some of its passengers and flight crew attempted to retake control of the plane, which the hijackers had redirected toward Washington, D.C. There are no survivors from any of the flights. Excluding the 19 hijackers, 2,974 people died in the attacks. The overwhelming majority of casualties were civilians, including nationals of over 90 different countries.

When the Towers Fell by Galway Kinnell

The banker is talking to London.
Humberto is delivering breakfast sandwiches.
The trader is already working the phone.
The mail sorter has started sorting the mail.

...povres et riches

...poor and rich

Sages et folz, prestres et laiz

Wise and foolish, priests and laymen

Nobles, villains, larges et chiches

Noblemen, serfs, generous and small

Petiz et grans et beaulx et laiz

Short and tall and handsome and homely

The plane screamed low down lower Fifth Avenue

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

lifted at the Arch, someone said, shaking the dog walkers
in Washington Square Park, drove for the north tower,
struck with a heavy thud, releasing a huge bright gush
of blackened fire, and vanished, leaving a hole
the size and shape a cartoon plane might make
if it had passed harmlessly through and were flying away
now,
on the far side, back into the realm of the imaginary.

Some with torn clothing, some bloodied,
some limping at top speed like children
in a three-legged race, some half dragged,
some intact in neat suits and dresses,
they straggle out of step up the avenues,
each dusted to a ghostly whiteness,
their eyes rubbed red as the eyes of a Zahoris,
who can see the dead under the ground.

Some died while calling home to say they were O.K.
Some died after over an hour spent learning they would
die.
Some died so abruptly they may have seen death from

4NG Fanatics

within it.
Some broke windows and leaned out and waited for
rescue.
Some were asphyxiated.
Some burned, their very faces caught fire.
Some fell, letting gravity speed them through their long
moment.
Some leapt hand in hand, the elasticity in last bits of love-
time letting — I wish
I could say — their vertical streaks down the sky
happen more lightly.

At the high window, where I've often stood
to escape a nightmare, I meet
the single, unblinking eye
lighting the all-night sniffing and lifting
and sifting for bodies, pieces of bodies, anything that is not
nothing,
in a search that always goes on
somewhere, now in New York and Kabul.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

She stands on a corner holding up a picture
of her husband. He is smiling. In today's
wind shift few pass. Sorry sorry sorry.
She startles. Suppose, down the street, that headlong
lope...
or, over there, that hair so black it's purple...
And yet, suppose some evening I forgot
The fare and transfer, yet got by that way
Without recall — lost yet poised in traffic.
Then I might find your eyes...
It could happen. Sorry sorry good luck thank you.
On this side it is "amnesia," or forgetting the way home,
on the other, "invisibleness," or never in body returning.
Hard to see clearly in the metallic mist,
or through the sheet of mock reality
cast over our world, bourne that no creature ever born
pokes its way back through, and no love can tear.

The towers burn and fall, burn and fall —
in a distant, shot, smokestacks spewing oily earth remnants
out of the past.
Schwarze Milch der Fruhe wir trinken sie abends

4NG Fanatics

Black milk of daybreak we drink it at nightfall
wir trinken sie mittags und morgens wir trinken sie nachts
we drink it at midday at morning we drink it at night
wir trinken und trinken
We drink it and drink it
This is not a comparison but a corollary,
not a likeness but a lineage
in the twentieth-century history of violent death —
black men in the South castrated and strung up from trees,
soldiers advancing through mud at ninety thousand dead
per mile,
train upon train headed eastward made up of boxcars
shoved full to the
corners with Jews and Gypsies to be enslaved or
gassed,
state murder of twenty, thirty, forty million of its own,
atomic blasts wiping cities off the earth, firebombings the
same,
death marches, starvations, assassinations, disappearances,
entire countries turned into rubble, minefields, mass
graves.
Seeing the towers vomit these black omens, that the last

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

century dumped into

this one, for us to dispose of, we know

they are our futures, that is our own black milk crossing the sky:

wir shaufeln ein Grab in den Luften da liegt man nicht eng

we're digging a grave in the sky there'll be plenty of room to lie down there

Burst jet fuel, incinerated aluminum, steel fume, crushed marble, exploded

granite, pulverized drywall, mashed concrete, berserked plastic,

gasified mercury, cracked chemicals, scoria, vapor

of the vaporized — wafted here

from the burnings of the past, draped over

our island up to streets regimented

into numbers and letters, breathed across

the great bridges to Brooklyn and the waiting sea:

astringent, miasmic, empyreumatic, slick,

freighted air too foul to take in but we take it in,

too gruesome for seekers of the amnesiac beloved

4NG Fanatics

to breathe but they breathe it and you breathe it.

A photograph of a woman hangs from a string

at his neck. He doesn't look up.

He stares down at the sidewalk of flagstone

slabs laid down in Whitman's century, gutter edges

rasped by iron wheels to a melted roundedness:

a conscious intelligence envying the stones.

Nie staja sie, sa.

They do not become, they are.

Nie nad to, myslalem.

Nothing but that, I thought,

zbrzydziwszy sobie

now loathing within myself

wszystko co staje sie

everything that becomes.

And I sat down by the waters of the Hudson,

by the North Cove Yacht Harbor, and thought

how those on the high floors must have suffered: knowing

they would burn alive, and then, burning alive.

and I wondered, Is there a mechanism of death

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

that so mutilates existence no one
gets over it not even the dead?
Before me I saw, in steel letters welded
to the steel railing posts, Whitman's words
written as America plunged into war with itself: City of the world!...
Proud and passionate city — mettlesome, mad, extravagant city!
words of a time of illusions. Then I remembered
what he wrote after the war was over and Lincoln dead:
I saw the debris and debris of all the dead soldiers of the war,
But I saw they were not as was thought.
They themselves were fully at rest — they suffer'd not,
The living remain'd and suffer'd, the mother suffer'd
And the wife and the child and the musing comrade
suffer'd...

In our minds the glassy blocks
succumb over and over into themselves,
slam down floor by floor into themselves.

4NG Fanatics

They blow up as if in reverse, exploding
downward and outward, billowing
through the streets, engulfing the fleeing.

As each tower goes down, it concentrates
into itself, transforms itself
infinitely slowly into a black hole

infinitesimally small: mass
without space, where each light,
each life, put out, lies down within us.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Galway Kinnell
Book: The Best American Poetry 2003
ISBN: 978-0743203876
Publisher: Scribner Poetry
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY